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Stop asking customers what they think

Customer research that predicts what people will actually do

Workshop · Guest lecture

ABSTRACT

Most customer research asks people what they think — would they use it, would they pay — and treats the answers as evidence. They are not. People are unreliable reporters of their own behavior: when Porter and Nohria tracked 27 CEOs minute by minute, their time went somewhere very different from where they believed it went. This session teaches research built on past and observed behavior: interviews that surface real workflows, workarounds and spend; how to tell normalized pain from complaints nobody would pay to fix; and how to define, before the conversation, which behaviors would confirm or end a hypothesis. Participants leave with question patterns they can use the next morning. The session is the hands-on companion to *Known before built*.

TAKEAWAYS

1. The evidence hierarchy: reported behavior beats opinion, and observed behavior beats both.
2. Interview question patterns that pull out past behavior, workarounds and spend instead of predictions.
3. How to set confirming and disconfirming behaviors before the interview, so findings cannot be bent to fit the plan.

WHO IT'S FOR

Anyone who talks to customers before deciding what to build: founders, product managers, researchers and innovation teams.

LENGTHS

Workshop 90 min or half day
Guest lecture 60–90 min

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